

50 million tweets

Popular microblogging site Twitter has crossed the 50 million tweets per day mark which works out to 600 tweets being sent each second.

A tablet with Core i7

Toshiba's Portege M780 hybrid tablet PC has a 2.66GHz Core i7 processor.

My Sunny Balcony: Green thumb grows into a fruitful business

Planting their way to success

Shreyasi Singh

readersletter@thinkdigit.com

When friends meet for coffee, big plans and even bigger dreams often brew. And sometimes, the caffeine kick may last long enough to change lives and cities. Ask 31-year-old Reena Chengappa and her band of boys, Shailesh Deshpande, Sriram Aravamudan and Athreya Chidambi. In December 2008, the four friends, all from Bangalore, nurtured one such session to grow an idea into a business venture.

Nature lovers and spirited eco-travellers all, they founded My Sunny Balcony, a garden consultancy, to design dream gardens for busy, urban professionals, and create little patches of green in concrete balconies across Bangalore's expanding high-rise suburbs.

"With so much construction you see felled trees everywhere here... This was once a city of bungalows with front lawns and backyards. We wanted to bring that back, to supplant our loss. It's a simple idea really. We have moved the front garden up the elevator to the balcony," explains 40-year-old Deshpande, also an environmental consultant.

The idea quickly bore fruit. Within a year, My Sunny Balcony has done over 30 concept balcony and terrace gardens in themes as varied as Zen, European and traditional Indian. An impressed customer base and an effective digital viral marketing strategy have ensured a steady stream of future projects. "This is not what we visualised. We began My Sunny Balcony as a weekend enterprise, a hobby. But, the response has surprised us. And now we mean business," says Chengappa who quit her Infosys content design job to work

full-time here. She says they broke even with the first project and are now "minimally profitable".

Thirty-three-year-old Aravamudan, a former software techie tries to decode their success. "We have been extremely lucky because we have hit the market at a time when there is a huge consciousness to go green. Our work ties in with that ethos." He too works full-time in the business now. The other two founder members, Deshpande and Chidambi, a web designer, have kept their day jobs and pitch in part time.

And, it's already time for reinforcements. My Sunny Balcony gets up to 20-30 enquiries a week but can manage only two or three client visits and two garden executions every week. It's also looking out for an intern garden designer who can independently execute projects.

None of this is surprising considering how no-fuss it really is to get your dream garden without once leaving home. The team begins with a site visit to analyse a client's needs, assess the area and understand their aesthetic sensibilities. Within a day or two, a garden design, which takes into account which plants to choose, what materials to source and custom made elements, is sent to the client. Fifty per cent of the project cost is taken in advance to buy raw material and the garden then typically takes a day for execution.

"We have done gardens in two



The Floral Four (L to R) Shailesh Deshpande, Athreya Chidambi, Sriram Aravamudan and Reena Chengappa get 20-30 enquiries every week.

days flat. All our gardens have been finished within two weeks of first meeting the customer," says Chengappa. A garden from them can cost anywhere between Rs 9,000-20,000 for a small balcony and Rs 50,000-Rs 60,000 for a terrace garden.

Now, plans are afoot to launch an online store that sells modular gardens. "We want people to come to our website, see our various theme garden design tips and order bamboo fencing, pots, wrought iron parapets to install their own gardens," says Deshpande.

A Gift-a-Garden option is also being worked out as is the vertical of annual maintenance contracts for the upkeep of gardens. They would like to expand to other cities but Aravamudan admits it's going to be tough with their existing skill set.

All you garden lovers outside Bangalore can rest assured because the wait is unlikely to be long. With what they have achieved so far, greening base patches is barely a challenge for this team. **d**